

Haligric Research Integration Series

SLAVIC PAGANISM

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

Russia, Poland, Ukraine -- Perun, Veles, Baba Yaga, Marzanna, and the Sacred World Before Christianity

Marzanna goes into the river. Winter goes with her.

We do not look back.

We come home with the green branch. This is how spring has always been made.

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Introduction -- The Sacred World Before Christianization

Slavic paganism -- the pre-Christian sacred tradition of the Slavic peoples (Russians, Poles, Ukrainians, Belarusians, Czechs, Slovaks, Serbs, Croats, Bulgarians, and related peoples) -- is one of the most significant and most underrepresented sacred traditions in the Western world's understanding of its own spiritual heritage. The Slavic peoples are the largest ethnic group in Europe, and their pre-Christian sacred tradition -- which was practiced across an enormous territory from the Elbe River to the Urals -- constitutes one of the richest mythological systems on the continent.

The primary challenge in studying Slavic paganism is the near-total destruction of the written record. Christianity arrived among the Slavic peoples from the 9th-12th centuries CE, and the Christianization process was thorough in its destruction of the previous sacred tradition's material expressions. What remains is reconstructed from chronicles written by Christian clerics (who described Slavic paganism in order to condemn it), from archaeological evidence, from the vast body of Slavic folk tradition (the byliny epic songs, the fairy tales, the seasonal ceremonies), and from comparative Indo-European mythology.

Key features: The Slavic sacred tradition belongs to the broader Indo-European religious family -- sharing fundamental structures with the Norse, Greek, Hindu, and Celtic traditions. Perun (thunder god) parallels Thor, Zeus, Indra, and the Celtic thunder gods. Veles (underworld) parallels Hades, Yama, and the Norse Hel. But the Slavic tradition has specific features -- particularly the Perun-Veles eternal conflict -- that distinguish it from all its Indo-European relatives. Dvoeverie (Double Faith): the specific way Slavic paganism survived Christianity -- not through complete conversion or complete persistence, but through a specific dual system where Christian practices and pagan practices coexisted, often with pagan seasonal ceremonies receiving a Christian saint's name while preserving their pagan content. Marzanna's drowning happens on the Sunday before Palm Sunday. Ivan Kupala Night is celebrated on the feast day of Saint John the Baptist. The content is pre-Christian; the calendar date carries the Christian name.

Who the Slavs Were -- The Largest Ethnic Group in Europe

The Slavic peoples are the largest ethnic group in Europe by population -- approximately 360 million people -- inhabiting an enormous arc from the Baltic to the Adriatic, from the Elbe to the Pacific coast of Russia. The Slavic language family (divided into East Slavic, West Slavic, and South Slavic branches) is one of the most widespread language families in the world, and the peoples who speak these languages share a common cultural and sacred heritage that, despite enormous diversity in its regional expressions, traces back to a common Proto-Slavic source.

The Proto-Slavs emerged as a distinct ethnic group somewhere in the forests of Eastern Europe -- most likely in the region of present-day Ukraine, Belarus, and Poland -- sometime in the first millennium BCE, though their specific origin point is debated. They inhabited the vast forested landscapes of the Eastern European plain, organized in kinship-based communities centered on specific territories and the specific sacred presences (the spirits of the forest, the field, the river, the household) that governed those territories. This forest-based, kin-based social organization shapes the specific character of the sacred tradition: Slavic paganism is fundamentally local, intimate, and oriented toward the specific sacred presences of the specific place.

Slavic Cosmology -- The World Tree and Three Realms

Slavic sacred cosmology understands the universe as organized around the World Tree (Mirovoye Drevo -- also called the Cosmic Oak, Svarga, or the Sacred Axis) -- a great tree whose roots reach into the underworld (Nav or Prav), whose trunk occupies the middle world of human existence (Yav), and whose branches reach into the heavens (Prav, the realm of the gods and the luminous world above). This three-realm structure -- identical in principle to the Norse three worlds of Yggdrasil, the Hindu three worlds, and the Baltic cosmological structure -- organizes the entire Slavic sacred universe.

The World Tree's specific sacred character: At its roots lives Veles and his domain of the ancestral dead, of hidden wisdom, of the underworld's moisture that makes the earth fertile. In its middle branches lives the human world, with its daily ceremonies of offering and acknowledgment. At its crown lives Perun, with his thunder and lightning, his fierce protection of the sacred order. The specific ecology of the World Tree is not a static cosmological diagram -- it is a dynamic field of tension in which Perun (above) and Veles (below) are in continuous conflict, and the World Tree is both the axis of this conflict and the specific sacred technology through which the human world maintains its own position between the two cosmic forces.

HALIGRIC LENS: The Slavic three-realm cosmological structure maps directly onto the Lithuanian three-world cosmology (the sacred pillar connecting the three realms), the Alabama-Coushatta three-world cosmology (the above, the this, and the below), and the Mandaean World of Light above and World of Darkness below with the human world suspended between. The specific names and specific contents of each realm differ. The structural understanding is the same: the human world exists at the sacred intersection between the above and the below, and the ceremonies that maintain its health must address both directions simultaneously.

Perun -- The Thunder God, Supreme Active Deity

Perun (from a Proto-Slavic root meaning "to strike" -- related to the Lithuanian Perkunas, the Baltic thunder god, and possibly to the Sanskrit Parjanya, the Vedic rain god) is the supreme active deity of the Slavic sacred world -- the god of thunder and lightning, of the sky and rain, of war and justice, and the sacred protector of the community against the forces of the underworld. Perun's domain: thunder, lightning, rain, war, sacred oaths, and justice. When Perun throws his lightning bolt, he is not acting randomly -- he is enforcing the sacred order against specific violators.

Perun's sacred animals and symbols: the oak (most sacred tree), the eagle (Perun's bird, riding the highest sky currents), the bull (masculine sacred power), the axe (specifically the stone axe -- the thunder ax -- as Perun's thrown weapon), fire. Perun's primary sacred site was not a built temple but a specific living oak tree -- the sacred grove of oak trees at specific locations (the most sacred being at Kiev, where a statue of Perun stood beneath oak trees with a sacred fire maintained before it). The oak's association with lightning (oaks are struck by lightning more frequently than other trees, and this was understood as Perun favoring his own tree) made it the natural sacred medium of the thunder god.

Perun as chief deity: In the Kievan Rus period -- the most extensively documented phase of Slavic paganism -- Perun was the primary deity of the prince's and warrior's class, invoked in oaths and sacred treaties. The 945 CE treaty between Prince Igor of Rus and the Byzantine Empire specifically invokes both Perun (the Varangian-Slavic god) and Volos/Veles for the oaths of the treaty parties -- giving us one of the earliest documented references to both deities.

Veles -- The Eternal Opponent, God of All the Hidden World

Veles (also Volos -- from a root related to "hair," "wool," or "ox") is the single most philosophically extraordinary figure in the Slavic pantheon -- a deity whose domain

encompasses the underworld, cattle, wealth, magic, the arts, poetry, and trickery. He is Perun's eternal opponent, and their conflict is the primary cosmic drama of the Slavic sacred world. Veles's domain: the underworld, the dead, the roots of the World Tree, cattle and wild animals, wealth and abundance (associated with the earth's fertility that the underworld's moisture produces), magic, poetry, music, trickery, and the arts. Veles is simultaneously more dangerous and more complex than Perun -- he is not evil (the Slavic tradition does not divide into good and evil in the Judeo-Christian sense) but he represents the principle of hidden power, of what is below and within, as opposed to Perun's above and manifest power.

Veles and the arts: One of Veles's most distinctive attributes -- and one of the most unusual for an underworld deity -- is his specific association with music, poetry, and the sacred arts. The volkhvy (the Slavic sacred specialists, the shamans) were understood as under Veles's specific protection. The byliny singers who preserved the epic tradition were under his patronage. The arts are underworld gifts -- they come from the deep, hidden places of existence, not from the clear sky above.

The Eternal Conflict -- Perun and Veles as Cosmic Principle

The Perun-Veles conflict is the defining cosmic drama of Slavic mythology -- Veles steals something from Perun's domain (cattle, children, a wife, water), retreats to the underworld or hides in a rock or tree, and Perun pursues him with lightning bolts. Every storm is this pursuit. When lightning strikes a tree, Perun is hunting Veles who has hidden there. When lightning strikes the ground, Perun is attacking Veles below. Rain that follows lightning is the release of the waters that Veles had imprisoned.

What distinguishes the Slavic understanding from a simple good-versus-evil narrative is that the conflict never ends and neither side permanently wins -- the cosmic order requires both Perun and Veles, both the principle above and the principle below, both the storm and the underground moisture that makes the earth fertile. Veles's defeat each time is not his elimination but his retreat to his own domain. The cycle continues because the cycle is the world. This is not a mythology of cosmic triumph; it is a mythology of cosmic balance maintained through continuous tension -- a sacred understanding that the universe is held together by the dynamic relationship between complementary forces, not by the permanent victory of one.

HALIGRIC LENS: The Perun-Veles eternal conflict is the Slavic tradition's most original philosophical contribution to the Haligrig library: the understanding that the sacred order is not maintained through the permanent victory of one principle over another but through the continuous dynamic tension between sky and underworld, manifest and hidden, order and depth. The Taoist understanding of yin-yang as complementary forces in continuous dynamic relationship. The Mandaean understanding of the World of Light and the World of Darkness maintained in balance by the specific sacred practices of the living community. Different cosmological vocabulary. The same recognition.

Rod and Rozhanitsy -- The Creator and the Fate Weavers

Rod (from the Slavic root meaning "birth," "clan," "generation" -- the same root as the word rodina, "homeland" or "birthplace," and of Rodnovery, "native faith") is understood in some Slavic scholarly traditions as the supreme creator deity -- the primordial being from whom all existence and all the other gods emerged. The Rozhanitsy (singular Rozhanitsa -- "she who gives birth") are the fate-weaving figures associated with Rod -- three female beings who appear at the birth of every child to weave that child's fate. The Slavic birth ceremony included specific offerings to the Rozhanitsy -- ritual acknowledgment that the fate-weavers were present at every birth and that their relationship with the newborn child required specific sacred acknowledgment from the beginning of that child's life.

Rod and the ancestral dimension: Rod's connection to the root meaning "birth" and "clan" means he is simultaneously a cosmic creator principle and the most intimate possible sacred presence -- the generative force that runs through family lineages, through the specific bloodlines that the Slavic people understood as their primary sacred community. To honor Rod is to honor the entire chain of ancestors who generated one's own existence.

The Slavic Pantheon -- All Major Deities in Full Depth

Beyond the primary deities, the Slavic sacred world includes: Svarog (the Sky Smith -- the Slavic equivalent of the divine craftsman, god of fire and metalworking, from whose forge the sacred fire of the sun emerges each day); Dazbog (the solar deity who gives abundance and gifts -- from "give" and "god/wealth"); Stribog (the wind deity and his grandchildren the winds of all directions); Lada (goddess of love, beauty, spring, and harmony); Jarilo (the spring god of new growth and fertility, killed each year at midsummer and reborn each spring -- a deity of death and resurrection); Kupala (or Kupalo, the midsummer deity -- closely connected to Jarilo and to the sacred fire and water ceremonies of midsummer); Simargl (the winged dog or griffin of fire, guardian of seeds and plants); Khors (associated with the sun's disk -- possibly a separate solar deity from Dazbog); Mokosh (the Earth Mother -- treated separately below).

Mokosh -- The Earth Mother and Sacred Feminine

Mokosh (from a Proto-Slavic root possibly meaning "moist" or "to spin" -- both interpretations connect to her domain) is the only goddess in the primary Slavic pantheon with documented evidence of state-level cult veneration. She was included in the pantheon of Prince Vladimir of Kiev in 980 CE -- the same prince who converted to Christianity in 988 CE and ordered the destruction of the Slavic sacred statues. Among the sacred figures thrown into the Dnieper River, only Veles's statue was reportedly not destroyed but carried to the shore by following worshippers. Mokosh's statue was among those whose destruction marked the end of the official Slavic sacred tradition.

Mokosh's domain: the earth's fertility, spinning and weaving (she protects spindles and is the patroness of women's domestic work), fate (she spins the thread of life), water (her name's root connects to moisture), and the specific feminine sacred wisdom associated with the deep earth. Mokosh is understood as Perun's opposite and complement in the cosmic order -- where Perun governs the sky and the lightning, Mokosh governs the earth and its deep moisture. Her relationship with Veles is complex -- both are associated with the underworld's fertile darkness, suggesting a deep affinity between the earth goddess and the underworld lord.

HALIGRIC LENS: Mokosh is the Slavic tradition's version of what every tradition in this library acknowledges: the supreme female sacred principle that governs the earth's fertility, the domestic sphere, the deep feminine wisdom that spins and weaves fate, and the relationship between human beings and the ground they stand on. Zemyna in Lithuania, Pachamama in the Inca tradition, Asherah in Canaanite tradition, the Earth Mother in the Alabama-Coushatta understanding -- each tradition has their own name for the sacred feminine principle that holds life together from below. Mokosh is the Slavic name.

Marzanna -- Goddess of Winter and Death, Step-by-Step Ceremony

Marzanna (Polish: Marzanna or Smiert-Marzanna -- "Death-Marzanna"; Czech: Morana or Smrtka; Slovak: Morena; Ukrainian: Mara) is the Slavic goddess of winter, death, disease, and the end of the dark season -- and the subject of one of the most remarkable surviving pre-Christian ceremonies in the world: the annual drowning of her effigy to drive away

winter and welcome spring. THIS CEREMONY IS LIVING -- it is practiced every year across Poland, Czech Republic, Slovakia, Ukraine, and Belarus.

Preparation (Days Before): The Marzanna effigy is constructed -- traditionally a straw figure in a white dress (white as the color of winter and of death in Slavic tradition), decorated with ribbons, beads, and specific winter symbols. The effigy is made by the community collectively, particularly by women and girls. Timing: typically mid-to-late March, on the Sunday before Palm Sunday or the first day of spring.

Step 1 -- The Procession: The community gathers carrying the Marzanna effigy through the village -- a noisy, celebratory procession with singing, music, and specific ceremonial songs that address Marzanna directly, commanding her to leave, to take winter with her, and to make room for spring.

Step 2 -- The Taunting Songs: During the procession, specific songs taunt Marzanna -- mocking her power, declaring her reign over, commanding her departure. The songs are simultaneously a ceremony and a declaration: winter is ending because we say it is ending.

Step 3 -- The Burning (In Some Traditions): Before reaching the water, some communities set the Marzanna effigy on fire -- the burning driving out winter by fire as a complement to the drowning.

Step 4 -- The Procession to the Water: The procession moves to the nearest river, stream, or body of water.

Step 5 -- The Drowning: The Marzanna effigy is thrown into the water -- sometimes pulled apart first (dismemberment of winter), sometimes thrown whole. The community watches it sink or float away.

Step 6 -- The Prohibition: After the drowning, no one may look back at the water. Looking back is understood as inviting winter to return.

Step 7 -- The Spring Symbol: The community returns to the village carrying a decorated tree branch (the Gaik or Litonoska -- the spring symbol) -- the living green of spring carried home in triumph to replace the dead straw of winter.

Kupala Night (Ivan Kupala) -- Step-by-Step

Kupala Night is the most powerful night in the Slavic sacred calendar -- the night of June 23-24 (the eve of the feast of Saint John the Baptist, hence "Ivan Kupala" -- pre-Christian timing was the summer solstice). The night when the boundary between the human world and the spirit world is thinnest, when sacred plants acquire their maximum power, and when specific sacred ceremonies of fire, water, and sacred herbs perform their maximum effect.

Step 1 -- The Sacred Fires: Large bonfires are lit -- the Kupala fire as the primary sacred element of the night.

Step 2 -- Jumping the Fire: Couples jump the bonfire together -- a sacred act of purification, of love affirmation, and of divination (if the joined hands are not broken as they cross the fire, the love is true).

Step 3 -- The Flower Crowns: Wreaths of sacred herbs and flowers are made -- specific plants gathered specifically for this night (St. John's Wort, ferns, meadowsweet) have their maximum sacred power on Kupala Night.

Step 4 -- The Water Divination: Flower crowns are set on the water with a candle -- the direction they float reveals sacred information about the year ahead.

Step 5 -- The Search for the Fern Flower: Young people go into the forest to search for the legendary fern flower -- which blooms only once a year on Kupala Night. The search is simultaneously a sacred quest, a courtship ritual, and a test of courage.

Step 6 -- The Sacred Herbs: Specific herbs gathered on Kupala Night are dried and kept for the year as medicine and sacred protection -- their power fixed by the night's specific sacred quality.

Step 7 -- The Dawn: The ceremony closes at dawn -- the community greeting the sunrise together as the sacred night's completion.

Baba Yaga -- The Forest Witch, Complete Sacred Portrait

Baba Yaga is the most distinctive and most philosophically complex figure in Slavic sacred tradition -- a supernatural being who lives in the deepest forest, in a house that stands on chicken legs, who simultaneously represents the most frightening possible encounter (she eats people) and the essential source of wisdom and sacred assistance for those who approach her correctly. Baba Yaga is simultaneously a goddess of death and transformation, the guardian of the threshold between the living world and the underworld, a crone figure of supreme wisdom, and a test-giver whose nature determines whether the hero receives her help or her destruction. She is not evil -- she is beyond good and evil, operating according to the specific sacred logic of the deep forest and the deep transformation that the hero needs.

Her house stands on chicken legs in the deep forest -- it turns itself when approached, presenting its back to the visitor. The specific instruction for entering: "House, house, turn your back to the forest and your face to me." The house's rotation on approach is Baba Yaga's first test -- only those who know the specific words can enter. Her character: an old woman with iron teeth and a bony leg (her name suggests "old bone leg"). She flies through the sky in a mortar, steering with a pestle and sweeping her tracks with a broom. The sacred test: every encounter with Baba Yaga is a test of sacred worth. The hero who arrives asking for help before bathing and eating -- before respecting the protocols of her household -- is refused or eaten. The hero who bathes, eats, and observes the specific protocols of guest-host relationship -- who approaches with courtesy, with specific sacred words, and with the correct intentions -- receives the specific wisdom or sacred object that the quest requires.

HALIGRIC LENS: Baba Yaga's ambiguity -- simultaneously the most dangerous being in the forest and the essential source of sacred wisdom -- reflects a genuine understanding of the sacred wisdom tradition. The deepest knowledge is not available without danger. The wisdom that transforms the hero cannot be safely delivered by a pleasant guide. Transformation requires encountering the figure who both threatens and enlightens. Every sacred tradition in the Haligrig library has a version of this figure: the ordeal that gives or withholds the gift depending on the seeker's intention and conduct.

The Firebird (Zhar-Ptitsa) -- Sacred Light and Transformation

The Firebird is a miraculous being whose feathers glow with the light of a thousand flames -- appearing at night, leaving the landscape transformed, sought by heroes in the most famous Russian sacred tales. The Firebird is simultaneously a specific sacred being and the principle of divine light manifested in the natural world -- the specific quality of sacred beauty that the hero is charged with capturing, protecting, or bringing back from the world's most dangerous places. A single feather from the Firebird illuminates a dark room; catching the Firebird itself requires extraordinary courage and specific sacred knowledge. The Firebird is always found in the garden of another powerful being (often Baba Yaga or a magical king) -- it is never freely available but must be sought and earned. It is what the tradition holds at the furthest reach of the sacred imagination: the beauty that transforms everything it touches, that cannot be possessed but only encountered.

The Household Spirits -- Domovoi, Dvorovoi, Kikimora

The Slavic household spirit tradition is one of the most developed and most practically oriented expressions of the broader European household spirit tradition -- a specific sacred ecology of beings who govern specific domestic spaces and whose proper acknowledgment maintains the household's wellbeing. The Domovoi (Master of the House): the primary Slavic household spirit -- understood as the spirit of the house's founding ancestor, inhabiting the domestic space and governing its wellbeing. The domovoi lives behind the hearth or under the threshold. He is felt rather than seen -- his presence manifests as specific sounds, specific sensations, specific impressions that experienced household members recognize. A pleased domovoi maintains the house's order; an offended domovoi causes specific disruptions. The Dvorovoi (Spirit of the Yard): the spirit who governs the yard and outbuildings, requiring specific acknowledgment to maintain peaceful coexistence. The Kikimora: a female spirit associated with spinning and weaving -- sometimes benevolent (assisting with household tasks) and sometimes malevolent (tangling thread, disrupting sleep, causing disorder). The kikimora's character depends on how she entered the household.

The Domovoi Ceremony -- Step-by-Step

Moving Into a New Home

Step 1 -- The Cat First: A cat is the first living being to enter a new home -- the cat serves as a preliminary spirit encounter, walking through the space and demonstrating by its behavior (where it rests, where it avoids) the specific spiritual geography of the new space.

Step 2 -- Bread and Salt: Bread and salt -- the sacred foods of Slavic hospitality -- are brought into the new home as the first household goods. These offerings acknowledge both the domovoi and the sacred traditions of hospitality.

Step 3 -- The Invitation to the Old Domovoi: In the tradition of moving from an old house, the departing family formally invites the old house's domovoi to accompany them to the new home -- speaking specific words at the old hearth, taking a coal from the old fire to kindle the new one.

Step 4 -- The First Fire: The first fire in the new home is kindled with specific prayers -- welcoming the domovoi to his new residence, acknowledging his authority over this space.

Ongoing Maintenance

Step 5 -- Nightly Acknowledgment: Specific foods (bread, salt, sometimes a small bowl of porridge) left near the hearth as regular acknowledgment of the domovoi's presence and care.

Step 6 -- The Prohibitions: Specific actions that offend the domovoi are avoided -- whistling indoors (considered an invitation to malevolent spirits), leaving the broom upright overnight, specific discourtesies at the threshold.

Step 7 -- Hearing the Domovoi: When the domovoi's presence is felt -- specific sounds, specific sensations -- the household member responds with specific acknowledgment rather than fear.

Rusalki and the Rusalia Festival -- Step-by-Step

The Rusalki (singular Rusalka) are the water spirits of Slavic tradition -- the spirits of girls and young women who died by drowning, by violence, or without fulfilling their life's purpose, whose unresolved spiritual energy remained in the water and made them simultaneously beautiful and dangerous. The Rusalki are understood as inhabiting rivers, lakes, and marshes -- particularly active during the Rusalia period (a week or two-week

period in late spring/early summer, corresponding roughly to Trinity Week in the Orthodox calendar). During Rusalia, the Rusalki emerge from the water and dance in the fields -- their dancing makes the grain grow, but their embrace can be fatal to those who encounter them without knowing the specific protective words and actions.

The Rusalia festival was the specific ceremony of propitiation and honoring of the Rusalki -- dances, songs, and specific offerings addressed to the water spirits, acknowledging their role in the agricultural fertility cycle while maintaining the specific protective protocols against their dangerous dimension. The Rusalia festival is one of the clearest examples of the Slavic sacred tradition's specific understanding of the dangerous-beautiful sacred: the most fertile sacred forces are not safe, and maintaining right relationship with them requires specific sacred knowledge rather than simple good intentions.

The Volkhvy -- Slavic Sacred Specialists and Shamans

The volkhvy (singular volkhv) were the Slavic sacred specialists -- the practitioners who maintained specific knowledge of the sacred world, who conducted the major ceremonies, who could communicate with the sacred beings, who interpreted omens and divined the future, and who conducted specific healing ceremonies. The volkhvy occupied a position in Slavic society parallel to the Lithuanian krivis, the Celtic druid, the Norse gothi, and the shaman in Siberian traditions -- all representing the specific social role of the person whose life is dedicated to maintaining the human community's relationship with the sacred world.

The volkhvy's specific knowledge: the specific ceremonies for each of the seasonal festivals, the specific protocols for each of the major sacred beings, the specific plants and their medicinal and sacred uses, the specific divinatory practices (reading the flight of birds, interpreting specific natural phenomena as omens), and the specific protective ceremonies against the dangerous dimension of the sacred world (the rusalki, the kikimora, the specific dangerous spirits of specific places). The volkhvy were the primary targets of Christianization's violence -- the destruction of their knowledge was the destruction of the sacred tradition's living transmission.

Slavic Paganism Under Christianity -- Dvoeverie (Double Faith)

Dvoeverie ("double faith" in Old Church Slavonic) is the specific way Slavic paganism survived Christianization -- not through complete conversion or complete resistance, but through a specific dual system where Christian and pagan practices coexisted within the same communities and often within the same ceremonies. The Orthodox Church absorbed specific pagan practices into its calendar; pagan seasonal ceremonies received a Christian saint's name while preserving their pagan content. The process was not always comfortable -- Orthodox chronicles and later sources repeatedly condemn specific folk practices as survivals of pagan religion -- but it was genuinely durable.

Specific examples: Marzanna's drowning ceremony, which happens on the Sunday before Palm Sunday -- the most explicitly anti-Christian ceremony in the Slavic calendar (the symbolic defeat of death before the Christian celebration of Christ's resurrection) persisted through centuries of Christianization. Ivan Kupala Night (Kupala Night), celebrated on June 23-24 -- the feast day of Saint John the Baptist -- preserved its midsummer fire-jumping, water divination, and flower crown ceremonies within a Christian calendrical framework. The domovoi tradition persisted in rural households well into the modern period, coexisting with icon corners and Christian prayer, because the household spirits' specific domain (the domestic wellbeing of the family) was never directly addressed by official Christianity.

Rodnovery -- The Living Contemporary Revival

The contemporary revival of Slavic paganism is organized under the name Rodnovery (Russian/Polish: Rodnoveriye/Rodnovierstwo -- from rod, "birth/clan/native," and vera, "faith" -- literally "native faith"). Rodnovery is a modern Pagan religion that seeks to reconstruct and revive the pre-Christian spiritual traditions of the Slavic peoples, centered on polytheistic veneration of deities, ancestors, and natural forces. It is the largest and most geographically distributed Pagan revival movement in Europe.

Key facts: Poland has five formally registered Rodnover religious organizations -- including Rodzima Wiara (Native Faith, established 1996) and the Native Polish Church -- with approximately 3,300 registered members as of 2022, plus many more informal practitioners. The National Rodnover Confederation was founded in Poland in 2015. Ukraine's Native Faith Association was founded in 1998 by Halyna Lozko, with chapters in Kyiv, Odessa, Lviv, Kharkiv, Chernihiv, and other cities; it is a member of the European Congress of Ethnic Religions. Russia has 40+ state-registered Rodnover organizations as of 2003, with hundreds of informal groups. Cambridge University Press published *Slavic Native Faith* (Aitamurto and Simpson) in 2026 -- available as a free download, marking serious scholarly recognition of Rodnovery as a significant contemporary religious movement.

The challenges of Rodnovery must be named honestly: Source scarcity is genuine -- unlike Hindu or indigenous traditions with unbroken lineages, Rodnovery must reconstruct from hostile Christian chronicles, comparative mythology, folk traditions, and archaeology, meaning interpretation necessarily fills gaps. The Book of Veles, treated as scripture by some Rodnover groups, is confirmed by scholarly consensus as a 20th-century forgery; the healthiest Rodnover communities acknowledge this. Nationalism is a genuine problem -- some Rodnover groups use Slavic paganism as a vehicle for ethnic supremacism and anti-immigrant ideology; this is well-documented and must be honestly acknowledged, even as other Rodnover communities explicitly reject it. The Russo-Ukrainian War (from 2022) has further complicated Rodnovery's landscape, with Ukrainian Rodnovers predominantly framing resistance as a sacred defense of ancestral lands, while Russian Rodnovers show significant internal division.

The living ceremonies persist regardless of Rodnovery's internal controversies: Marzanna is drowned every spring across Poland, Czech Republic, Slovakia, Ukraine, and Belarus. Kupala Night bonfires are jumped every midsummer. The domovoi still lives behind the hearth in the understanding of households that remember. These ceremonies are not Rodnovery's invention -- they are the continuous folk tradition that Rodnovery has organized around.

The Haligrity Lens -- The Eternal Conflict as Sacred Teaching

The Slavic tradition's most original philosophical contribution to the Haligrity library is the Perun-Veles eternal conflict -- the understanding that the sacred order is not maintained through the permanent victory of one principle over another but through the continuous dynamic tension between sky and underworld, manifest and hidden, order and depth.

Every storm is the same battle. Perun descends with his lightning, Veles retreats with what he has taken, the rain comes when Veles releases the water, and the world is fed. Neither wins permanently because the world requires both. The domovoi lives behind the hearth right now. Baba Yaga is in the deep forest waiting to eat you or help you depending entirely on whether you know the right words and have the right intentions. Marzanna's effigy goes into the river every spring across Poland and Ukraine -- the drowning of winter is not metaphor, it is a ceremony that has been performed continuously for more than a thousand years. The sacred world before Christianity is not past tense. It drowned the straw woman and came home with the green branch. Grand Rising.